

BEFORE

Japan's desire to build an empire in Asia and the Pacific drew it into conflict with China and met with condemnation from the US.

JAPANESE EXPANSION IN ASIA

In 1931 the Japanese took control of Manchuria 424–25 >> a vast region now in northeast China, and established the state of Manchukuo there. China was the first target in Japan's plan to create an empire in Asia and the Pacific, and it soon began to stage incursions into Chinese territory. In July 1937 a minor incident, involving a missing Japanese soldier, caused Japanese and Chinese forces to open fire on each other at the Marco Polo Bridge near Beijing. The conflict quickly escalated, leading to the second Sino-Japanese war and ultimately to both countries' involvement in World War II. Although European colonial interests were affected, they were absorbed by growing problems in Europe and resisted involvement.

US FREEZES DEPOSITS

German victories at the beginning of World War II encouraged Japan to start empire building in earnest. It signed the Three-Power Pact with Germany and Italy in 1940 and occupied French Indochina (Vietnam). The US responded by freezing Japanese deposits in the US and embargoed exports of crucial materials, such as aviation fuel, to Japan.

War in the Pacific

In 1941 Japan attacked the US navy base at Pearl Harbor, throwing down the gauntlet to all Western powers seeking to restrict the expansion of the Japanese Empire. The US and Britain immediately declared war on Japan. World War II had arrived in Asia and the Pacific and was now truly global.

US president Franklin D. Roosevelt had transferred his navy's battleship force to Pearl Harbor, Hawaii in April 1940, to deter Japanese aggression. The combined effects of war with China and foreign trade embargoes left Japan desperate for oil and other raw materials available in European colonies in the Southeast Asia and the East Indies. The Japanese raid on Pearl Harbor destroyed many US battleships and killed around 3,000 US personnel, reducing the threat to Japan's southward expansion.

Having gained an advantage, Japanese leaders put their plans into action. Their aim was to construct an

imperial perimeter around Southeast Asia and the central Pacific. Pearl Harbor was followed by the Japanese invasion of most of their target territories, including Burma, British and Dutch Borneo, Hong Kong, and the Dutch East Indies. Between March and June of 1942, the Japanese survived fierce confrontations with Allied forces to conquer Singapore, Guam, and the Philippines, and established control in Indonesia, Malaya, and Burma. Having ousted the old colonial regimes, Japan made attempts to win over the mass of Asian peoples so that they would support them in the war. A degree of independence was granted to a few



Burma river patrol

Forces were sent into Burma to protect British colonial interests in the country. In the picture above, British troops patrol villages along a river as they search for Japanese soldiers.

